Carl Linnaeus



Born in rural southern Sweden, Linnaeus was educated at the University of Uppsala, where he began teaching botany in 1730. He spent three years in the Netherlands, and, on returning to Sweden, he divided his time between teaching, writing, and plant-collecting expeditions. At Uppsala, 17 of his students embarked on expeditions all over the world. Linnaeus was a friend of Anders Celsius, the inventor of the temperature scale. After his friend's death, Linnaeus reversed the scale so that freezing point was 32°F (0°C) and boiling point 212°F (100°C). Linnaeus has been described as the "prince of botanists," and the philosopher Rousseau said of him "I know no greater man on Earth." Linnaeus is buried in Uppsala Cathedral; his remains constitute the type specimen—the specimen that represents a species—used for *Homo sapiens*.

Key works

1735 *Systema Naturae*

1737 *Flora Lapponica*

1751 *Philosophia Botanica*

1753 *Species Plantarum*

See also: Classification of living things • Biological species concept • A modern view of diversity